

ISTQB Foundation Glossary

Forty key terms and concise definitions for the Foundation exam.

Introduction

Precise vocabulary is worth easy marks in the ISTQB Foundation exam. This glossary lists forty of the most examined terms with concise, syllabus-aligned definitions. Learn to distinguish the pairs that are easy to confuse — error/defect/failure and verification/validation especially.

Core Glossary

Term	Definition
Error (mistake)	A human action that produces an incorrect result.
Defect (bug, fault)	A flaw in a work product that can cause a failure; the result of an error.
Failure	An event in which a component or system does not perform a required function within limits.
Root cause	The underlying source of a defect that, if removed, prevents recurrence.
Quality	The degree to which a component or system satisfies the stated and implied needs of stakeholders.
Verification	Confirmation that specified requirements have been met — "are we building the product right?"
Validation	Confirmation that requirements for a specific use are fulfilled — "are we building the right product?"
Testing	The set of activities to evaluate quality and reduce the risk of failure in operation.
Debugging	The development activity that finds, analyses and fixes the cause of a defect (not the same as testing).
Test object	The component or system to be tested.
Test basis	The body of knowledge used as the basis for designing test cases (e.g. requirements).
Test condition	An aspect of the test basis relevant to achieving test objectives.
Test case	A set of preconditions, inputs, actions, expected results and postconditions developed to meet a test condition.
Test scenario	A sequence of related actions/events, often a realistic user journey covering several test conditions.
Test procedure (script)	A sequence of test cases in execution order with any preconditions to run them.

Term	Definition
Test suite	A set of test cases or procedures to be executed together.
Test data	Data created or selected to satisfy the preconditions and inputs of tests.
Expected result	The predicted behaviour of a test object under specified conditions, from the test basis.
Test oracle	A source to determine expected results (specification, another system, or a person).
Static testing	Testing a work product without executing code (reviews and static analysis).
Dynamic testing	Testing that involves executing the software.
Test level	A group of test activities organised and managed together (component, integration, system, acceptance).
Test type	A group of test activities focused on specific quality characteristics (functional, non-functional, structural, change-related).
Functional testing	Testing what the system does — its functions and features.
Non-functional testing	Testing how well the system behaves — performance, usability, security, reliability, etc.
White-box testing	Testing based on the internal structure of the test object (structure-based).
Black-box testing	Testing based on specifications without reference to internal structure.
Regression testing	Testing to detect defects introduced or uncovered by a change elsewhere in the software.
Retesting (confirmation testing)	Re-running tests that previously failed to confirm a fix works.
Smoke test	A subset of tests confirming the most critical functions work before deeper testing.
Severity	The degree of impact a defect has on the system or its operation.
Priority	The urgency with which a defect should be fixed (business-driven).
Equivalence partitioning (EP)	Dividing inputs into partitions where members are expected to be treated the same; test one per partition.
Boundary value analysis (BVA)	Testing at the edges of equivalence partitions, where defects cluster.
Decision table testing	Deriving tests from combinations of conditions and their resulting actions.
State transition testing	Testing valid and invalid transitions between states of a system.
Coverage	The degree, as a percentage, to which specified items have been exercised by a test suite.
Traceability	The ability to link test items (conditions, cases) back to the test basis and requirements.
Entry criteria	The preconditions that must be met to start a test activity.
Exit criteria	The conditions that must be met to declare a test activity complete.

The Most Confused Pairs

- Error → Defect → Failure: a person makes an error, which introduces a defect, which may cause a failure when executed.
- Verification vs Validation: building it right (to spec) vs building the right thing (fit for use).

- Severity vs Priority: how bad the defect is vs how soon it should be fixed.
- Retesting vs Regression: confirming a specific fix vs checking the fix broke nothing else.

Best Practices

- Learn the exact ISTQB wording, not a paraphrase.
- Practise the confused pairs until they are automatic.
- Use the terms consistently in your own work.

Common Mistakes

- Using "bug" loosely for error, defect and failure interchangeably.
- Swapping verification and validation.
- Assuming high severity always means high priority.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

When an exam question mixes "error", "defect" and "failure", slow down and map the chain: human error creates a defect in the code; the defect causes a failure only when that code is executed. Most trick questions hinge on this exact sequence.